

Lesson 12: Thriving Together: Women Supporting Women

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What would the world be like if we all supported each other? If we saw our colleagues as comrades-in-arms and not competition or obstacles in our way?

Maybe you've had these thoughts before too. How can women do a better job of championing and supporting other women, especially in leadership roles?

Pat would be the first to tell us all to intentionally celebrate the victories of other women in the workplace and have an "abundance" mindset. Eliminate any trace of a "scarcity" mindset that might propel you to view other co-workers – male or female – as competition in your own organization. What a joy it is to celebrate others who are navigating the same twists and turns of leadership and doing it well. Adopt a "You Win, I Win," mindset!

You also want to ensure that you include strong female leaders on your support team...and we all need a support team! This means intentionally creating your own championship team with its own set of players to help you in your own career journey.

There are a few people you want to include:

First, "Work BFFs" – these are the people who are with you in the daily grind, who bring a smile to your face and make work a pleasure. Or maybe they provide a much-needed comic relief when you need to unwind, reminding you everything is going to be OK. These types of team members are everywhere and may not share your exact title or status and that's OK.

Next are Comrades-in-Arms – these are colleagues who are "in the trenches" with you. They may share a similar job description or be in a partnership role.

Coaches are those who may or may not work at your business but have worked in your industry or in the workplace for many years and can offer encouragement.

Finally, mentors. Everyone needs mentors! A mentor isn't a peer or a "coach." Their job isn't to make you feel good, but rather to give you insight and pass on experience. Mentors can be male or female and are usually a little older than you are. They might have experience in an industry you are trying to break into or a skill you can learn to acquire.

We all know what it feels like to have someone who believes in us, someone who is on your side. I was fortunate to have some really strong mentors along my career path. Women

that showed me by their own example that success is more than just my career, that I need to use my visibility to lead in the community beyond the workplace.

You might ask a mentor certain questions like:

How did you get to where you are today?

Are there specific skills or experiences you recommend I focus on? or

What strategies do you recommend for professional development?

We'll go over all this in the upcoming lesson.